

Componential Model of Creativity

Expertise × creative-thinking skills × intrinsic motivation

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Amabile's componential model proposes that individual creativity is the product of three components: **domain-relevant skills** (expertise and knowledge), **creativity-relevant processes** (cognitive styles and idea-generation techniques) and **task motivation** — with intrinsic motivation the decisive multiplier. A surrounding organisational component (the social environment) either fuels or suppresses the three.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Developed by Harvard Business School psychologist Teresa Amabile from the 1980s onward, refined across her career and updated in *Creativity in Context* (1996) and her 2019 retrospective.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Amabile wanted to move creativity research out of the study of rare geniuses and into everyday organisational settings, and to show empirically that the social environment — not just innate talent — shapes how creative people actually are.

HOW IT IS USED

Managers diagnose which component is limiting output. If expertise is thin, they train; if idea-generation is weak, they teach techniques; but Amabile's central finding is that killing intrinsic motivation (through surveillance, harsh evaluation or the wrong incentives) collapses creativity regardless of skill.

WHEN IT IS USED

When designing reward systems, structuring creative work, or troubleshooting a talented team that has stopped producing original work.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Managers, team leads, HR designers and educators responsible for the conditions under which knowledge workers create.

FIGURE 1 · PROCESS VIEW

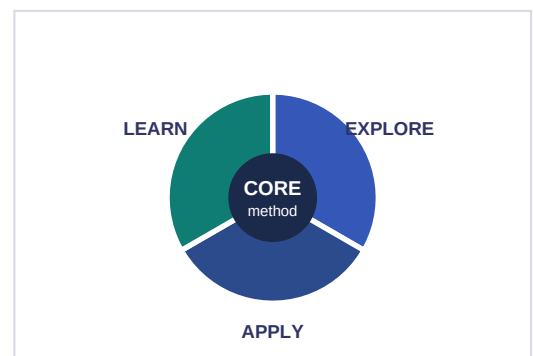


Figure 1. Componential Model of Creativity framed as a continuous, iterative method — explore, apply and learn cycle back through the work rather than run once.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

Where the 4 P's named the strands, Amabile **quantified their interaction** and proved experimentally that intrinsic motivation and a supportive climate drive creative performance — reframing creativity as a managerial variable, not a fixed trait.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

[The 4 P's of Creativity](#) *Slibrary 1*

[Psychological Safety](#) *Slibrary 2*

[SCAMPER](#) *Slibrary 1*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Amabile, T.M. (1998) 'How to Kill Creativity', *Harvard Business Review*, 76(5), pp. 76–87.

Amabile, T.M. (1996) *Creativity in Context*. Boulder, CO: Westview Press.